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Christian Sands

Pianist/composer Christian Sands has recorded with Christian McBride, Bobby Sanabria and Gregory Porter. He leads his own trio and records his original work on the Mack Avenue label.

Christian was interviewed in Clinton, New York on February 2, 2019 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College and I'm very pleased to have Christian Sands here this evening.

CS: Thank you.

MR: I'm looking forward to your concert in the beautiful Wellin Hall.

CS: Yeah, that's beautiful.

MR: 700 seat.

CS: Absolutely beautiful. Sounds fun in there.

MR: Does the sound of a hall affect your song list?

CS: Yeah, yes, yes it does.

MR: How so?

CS: Because well it affects not only the song list but how you play, how you present the music. Because you know you want to have fun in the space that you're in you know, so if you have a dry space you might play tunes that kind of fit that mold or fit that type of — you know it's brightly lit so you want to do bright songs, or something like — or something to darken the mood. You know you've kind of got to figure out how to play with the environment that you're in, you know. Yeah.

MR: I had an interesting experience mid-week I happened to catch a Nat King Cole documentary. And near the end they talked about the song "L-O-V-E" which was a hit for him. And the next day I found you playing "L-O-V-E" on a video for WGBO. Do you remember it?

CS: I do. I do remember it.

MR: So the song "L-O-V-E" at a medium tempo probably takes about 40 seconds to play. And you and your trio made it a 9 minute performance.

CS: Oops.

MR: Well I never lost interest, and to me it was sort of like this master class in how does that happen — how do you take a song, a short song, and have you ever had to explain how you do that to someone?

CS: No. No, I never had to. But if I had to, I mean you know it's about expression, you know, it's about a journey, it's about starting from point A to point B, or point C, D, you know.

And how do we get there? We get there through our ideas and the way we want to present the music, but also just the way the music wants to present itself. You know? If you're open to it the music kind of dictates what it wants to do, so you just have to kind of listen to it as you go. And it'll kind of give, it's strange I know, but it will kind of give ideas to you as you play along, so it kind of does it by itself.

MR: You started out with a piano introduction. And at one point the camera was mostly on you so that actually caught this thing you did. You were playing along and you looked up and your bass player and drummer were over there, and you went like this [gestures] near the end of a chorus. And they stopped, which meant they were paying attention, right?

CS: Right, right. Luckily.

MR: And then you played some almost stride stuff. And I said oh that's another way to stretch out a thing is take away their sound and bring it back in.

CS: Yeah. It's all about construction. You know if you take certain things away it has a different feeling. It has a different intention, it has a different sound you know. If you don't play and other things happen it still has something, you know it still has a certain sound, it still has a certain feeling. You know, so when you play around with that, whether the bass drops out or I drop out or the drums drop out, you know, it's still the song, it's still the form that we're doing, but there is a different, there's a different sound and color now you know. It's still the same exact thing that we've been doing but now you're kind of taking pieces apart from it and putting it back together and placing things differently, you know, turning it around, turning it upside down, you know, all that, but it's still the same exact piece you're just now looking at it or listening to it at a different angle.

MR: And lastly regarding this performance, when you were playing by yourself you went up a half step.

CS: Yeah.

MR: And I wondered if your compatriots, especially the bass player, did he know you were going to do that?

CS: Probably not.

MR: Probably not.

CS: Probably not. I mean this was — the recording that we did, I mean that video was actually just purely just us testing the sound of us, so it wasn't like a pre-thought piece that we were going to play for the show, we just ended up, it was just in the car while we were driving there and so well let's just play it. You know. It was just something to warm us up, set us up. So with that modulation there, no, he wasn't aware of it, but you know he's a great bass player so when he hears that little movement he knows exactly what to do.

MR: Well do you think in G flat or F sharp?

CS: Either/or.

MR: It didn't seem to faze you at all. That's a lot of black keys.

CS: I like it. You know? I mean it is what it is, whether you think of it as F sharp or E double sharp, you know, it's all about the feeling, it's all about the emotion, and how you present the music. So it's all about that. So I usually don't think of keys as keys, I usually think of them as gestures and feelings, and you know this feeling, G flat or F sharp now is a brighter feeling than what I had before. You know? F is this happy feeling, this type of mode that we're in, this type of feeling, and now we raise it, now we're just getting brighter, now we're getting more alert, now we're getting — you know, so that's kind of how I think about it.

MR: Nice. "L-O-V-E" in G flat.

CS: Exactly.

MR: I see that you're a composer, you can go from playing a Nat King Cole standard into your very adventurous compositions. What inspires you to write?

CS: Man, that's tough because it's so many different things, it's not like one answer for that. You know, I write all the time. I write, again depending on moods, depending on emotion, depending on who I'm talking to, my inspiration comes from everything. From people, from stories, from you know watching certain movies or hearing certain soundtracks or hearing certain songs or hearing certain, you know, sounds you know, out in the world. Like you hear a dog bark or something like that and you'll be like man that actually sounds really cool with a siren in the background. So let's figure that out. You know? And that turns into something. So I'm always influenced by just the world and what's happening.

MR: How do you know when a tune is done?

CS: It never is. You know? I always feel like it never, ever is. It's done for the day, but you know I mean like everything, everything I've recorded, you know there's always, you record it and it's like cool, but then the next time you play it it's a totally different thing. So each time you record something it's like a totally different song. So and then you have to pick which one you like, which is always the tough part.

MR: "Freefall." I'm fascinated by that song. First of all I'm wondering —

CS: What it's about?

MR: Where in the process — that's sort of my question. Where did the title, when did the title come?

CS: Well you know it was actually — funny enough you're the only person that's ever asked me about that song by the way. You know. Thank you.

MR: Well there's something I want to specifically ask you.

CS: Well actually it came from a break-up actually. It came from breaking up with this girl that I was in love with and it came from a dream. The entire song actually unfolded in like this dream of — I won't tell you the entire dream but really it was the idea of trying to reach somebody without knowing who they are, there's this person that exists and you try to bring them into your world and bring them into something that you think is fascinating and you think is nice, but then once you try to do that you can't. You can't attain that person. You can't hold on to that person. That person kind of just scatters all over the place and then they disappear and then you're left wondering what happened. Did I do something right, did I do something wrong, very contemplative type of song and that's what the whole thing was when it was going on. So that's what the song is about. That's what "Freefall" is all about.

MR: Nice.

CS: Yeah.

MR: You've got that little piano vamp up front, right? And I was trying to figure it out. And the best I could do was I sketched this two measures thing there, I don't know if there's an F sharp in the bass or something?

CS: Sort of, yeah.

MR: Sort of. And I don't know if I'd pass on melodic or chordal dictation but that set sort of a harmony for me in my ears. And then this melody comes in and where did that come from? It sounds like it's in a different key.

CS: Right. Well the whole reasoning of that was in the dream, you know, to set it up, in the dream it was just me dreaming and it's dark and so there's no floor, no ceiling, no sides, no walls anything like that. So that's where the ambiguous — is it in F sharp, is it not in F sharp comes from. And then the line appears, and the line kind of appears out of nowhere, where the figure appears out of nowhere. You know? I know, it's a whole method to this whole thing. You know, but there's still no walls, no ceiling, so there's still no bass, no set time necessarily —

MR: I'm glad you said that because I couldn't find it.

CS: It's just kind of spacey and open and then as the dream goes on, you know, more structure starts to form and everything starts to form just like the dream did, and then it finally, at the end, the thing disappears, the apparition or whatever you want to call it, disappears and so does the rest of the time and the rest of the bass and you know, now there's just me again. You know. That's what the whole thing is about.

MR: Freefalling. Nice.

CS: Exactly.

MR: And lastly that I really liked that because I think you had a either a sax or a bass clarinet or something, doubled with the string bass.

CS: Um hum. Both. Yes.

MR: Very cool.

CS: Thank you, thank you.

MR: I mean orchestration is a big part of pulling this —

CS: Yeah, well I like, especially with Marcus Strickland — one, I'm just a big fan of his music and his work and the way he plays his instrument. But also he's an amazing doubler, you know and he plays almost all the woodwinds too. But he's such a master at bass clarinet, you know, and that was something that he was starting to do more of, and so when we were playing together it was like, "Man, bring your clarinet." You know? Because it has such a nice, woody, warm, earthy tone to it you know, especially the way he plays it. You know. And that combination with him playing the tenor and then Yasushi playing bass, you know, kind of has this certain earth tone to it, this certain grounding to it, but still has this really ambiguous sound of like what is it exactly. You know. So that's why I kind of wanted to combine all those together.

MR: Nice. You did music college. Was it Manhattan you went to?

CS: Yup. Manhattan School of Music.

MR: Is that the — pretty much the only way for young musicians now to take the jazz path?

CS: No, I won't say that's the only way, but it is a good way to meet other musicians and to form these connections with people that are around your same age. You know, I mean if I didn't go to college or Manhattan School of Music or a conservatory would I still be in the position I am today? I'm sure I would be. But I think I would have had a lonelier time getting there versus now, now I have colleagues, now I have people that I graduated with that we play music together, or I see them in other bands around as we're on the road and we get to finally catch up, so it's this nice community that you have, the people you graduate with or the people you go to school with that are either ahead of you or behind you. You know like I went to school with Ambrose Akinmusire I went to school with Linda Oh, I went to school with Sam Harris, Sam Harris, Fabian Almazan, you know the list goes on and on of the people that I went to — I was underneath you know. And so it was great when I got to school to see those people working and those people in bands like Terence Blanchard's band or, you know, or playing with Christian McBride or playing with Ravi Coltrane you know, and going to see them in New York and knowing that I can also see them in the lunch room, which is really — and talk to them about the gig and bug them, for me being the freshman. But schooling is such an important part of the development of the music, but also just the development of you as a person you know, and getting to know those connections of people that, you know, you go to class with or you have these friends or you have these people that you've heard about. You know like when I was in school I also met Jonathan Battiste. We were in school at the same time,

and so we met in a practice room at Manhattan School of Music. That was the first time we met, and that was like four o'clock in the morning. So you don't really get that if you don't go to school you know. But not to say that you won't ever meet another musician you know, but there is a certain thing that comes with going to schools and learning and being in classes and being around other people that are also very creative and then you never know what happens.

MR: How do you learn to sort of take care of the bandstand, to present a concert? Because there's more to it than just what you play.

CS: Oh yeah. I mean it's a lot of studying. I mean I believe that anyway. You know everyone's different. But for me I like to study the greats. I like to study the people that I admire. Like you watch Miles Davis it's like what do I like about that besides the playing part, besides everybody in the band that's playing, but also when you watch these videos it's like okay how does he direct the band? How does he present the music even though his back is turned sometimes? You know like how does that even work? Or you watch videos of Thelonious Monk and then he dances. You know like why does he do that? What does that do to the audience? What does that do to the band? You watch Chris Botti and how he presents music and what happens. Or I mean not even jazz musicians. I mean you go to, like I went to a Beyonce and Jay-Z concert the other day and it was just like amazing you know. Not only because of the pyrotechnics and the staging and all of that, because that is incredible and it gives an amazing impression on you, but also how does that tie in with the talent that they all have? The talent of the band that you see actually on stage you know, what they're doing, when they do it, what is the wardrobe that they have on, what's the lighting that is there that presents this certain mood and atmosphere to present that song. You know, what goes with what. So there's a lot of things that I watch and I study to make sure that you know this trio that I have, or solo piano or whatever it is, is presented correctly.

MR: Do you have a drummer list, a bass player list, and you line up gigs and a tour and you've got to figure out who's available?

CS: Yeah I mean you have your main guys that you always use, you know, and then you have the guys that if they're not available who also — it's not even also it is a substitute because they also are equally as good. It's just you have your people that you know that you don't have to rehearse with, they just know the music and then you know it's less work for you to do on that side of it. So those are the guys. And then you have the ones like okay if we do one rehearsal they'll be fine. You know, cool. And then you have the guys like okay if we do two rehearsals that will be fine. And then you know you just keep going and going and going. You know. But yeah, there's always a set of people that you kind of have, but then you also learn about other people. You learn about new people and

then you try to figure out okay where can I put this now because I really want to play with this person now. But now this person is used to me calling him all the time so how do we do that? When do we do that? Or just call them both. And now you just have a double trio or something like that. You know? Options.

MR: What would cause you to not call somebody back that, even though they might be a really good player? Is there anything that sort of irks you?

CS: I mean if they're just not professional, you know? Like if anyone is just unprofessional or you know just not a nice person. I mean you'd be surprised — you can be the most talented person in the world but if no one likes you they won't call you. You know. Like if you're not easy to work with or there's always a thing then it's not going to work out. And you can be like the fifth most talented person in the room or so, and if you're easy to work — and you come correct, and you come with all your music ready and like everything is in place and professional, you'll get so many more gigs like that. And then you also learn on the bandstand to be better and better and better and better and better. So you know, that's kind of how I see it.

MR: Geri Allen was important in your career?

CS: Um hum.

MR: What did you learn from her?

CS: Oof. What didn't I learn? She was just a beautiful person man, a beautiful spirit and an amazing, amazing pianist and composer and everything. Amazing mother. I got to spend a lot of time with her and her kids. And you know I just learned how to be a warm person you know, and how to present music, and actually how to study music. Her and Wynton Marsalis actually taught me how to really study music. And you know, prepare for things and prepare for concerts and prepare for, you know, just a musical life ahead of me. You know when I'm asked to be a musical director or I'm asked to write arrangements of things, you know don't just do it, do it with education behind it, do it with study, do it with information behind it. Don't just — oh yeah I'm talented and I can do that, but also combine that with what you learned or what you studied. So both of them were really impactful of how I go about music.

MR: Nice. And you took over from her with the Errol Garner project?

CS: Um hum. I did. I did, which is a lot of fun, going deep into archives and finding things. You know we found a whole bunch of new things that haven't existed before so we're trying to figure out what to do with those things at the moment but it's a lot of really, really, really exciting things. Yeah.

MR: I found a YouTube comment —

CS: Uh oh.

MR: A comment on a YouTube and I wanted to see what you think of this.

CS: Okay.

MR: It was regarding a thing you did on "Yesterday" the Paul McCartney —

CS: You should have one of the students read it. You should. Then that way it sounds more like a millennial.

MR: Come up here. Okay. So this is a YouTube on your performance on "Yesterday."

CS: All right. Be easy on me too man.

XX: So an unintentional touch of Errol Garner at the start, Christian's left hand was on the beat, not a fraction behind, as in Garner's case. Should he have approached this McCartney evergreen. Excellent rendition, Christian, keep on keeping on.

CS: Okay, cool. I was worried for a minute.

MR: No, no, it was a compliment. But I like the thing he said about —

XX: The show from Dizzy's was on the livestream webcast. It was dynamite.

CS: Thank you, thank you.

MR: But apparently he thinks Errol would have played a little more behind the beat.

CS: Yeah, sure. You know, but that's the difference because I'm not him. But you know Errol has influenced all of piano you know, purposely and also accidentally. Because there's a lot of pianists I'm sure that they don't even think about him when they play but he's in there, you know, out of just functionality of how he used the piano. I mean everything he did made so much sense to do. How to play jazz piano. He's one of the masters of how to actually play it you know, how to shape music. How to be free within the form and you know how to cue things. I mean everything he did really, when you really look at it it's really incredible.

MR: Can you expand on that a little bit, how to be free within the form? What's the first step of being free?

CS: Well I mean it depends on who you are. Because being free for another musician might be just playing the changes and playing them all perfectly. And that's free. That's wonderful. You know, and it depends on who you are. For me being free within the form, you know I actually haven't figured out how to say it yet, because I do it but I haven't figured out how to exactly like harness it. Because it's something that I think we're all trying to figure out exactly how we want to play the music you know whether it's listening to Herbie Hancock and how he plays music and how he plays form and where he places things. I mean whether it's rhythm, harmony, melody, I mean you know it all depends. Everybody has a different way of doing it.

MR: Well I think that's sort of the magic of the music is that you can do it but not necessarily put into words what is happening.

CS: Yeah. It's hard to do. It's hard to say. You know it's kind of like asking a painter, well how do you paint? You know there's a method, sure. But then after that? How does Picasso do what Picasso does? I don't know. I appreciate it though.

MR: If I could land some kind of grant from some office at Hamilton College and I could commission you to write a new suite, where would you start?

CS: Well I'd probably have to spend some time here first. Because I don't know anything about it.

MR: Think we could arrange for that?

CS: Yeah I'd spend a little bit of time here, and then after that, you know, spend some time with the students, spend time with the faculty, spend some time on the grounds, spend some time eating the food, you know, and really get the experience of what it is to be here you know. And then you begin to write. Then you begin to shape what it is you want the suite to be. You know, because the suite should represent what it is about you know. And so I'd need to know everything there is to know about the school.

MR: Do you feel like you have — I'm not sure how to say this — a vocabulary for your own composing that if you sit down and you do this it's going to give me an emotion or some kind of feeling?

CS: Yeah I think so. I mean I think we all do. And it's just the more you live the more experience you have the wider that vocabulary becomes you know. It starts off, I mean I think everybody starts off pretty similarly, you know, with root voicings and scales and those type of things. And then you kind of branch off as you experience life — you kind of approach them differently. You put them in different situations because you've been in different situations you know. I think they all reflect who they are as a person and whether your vocabulary is highly offensive and you just have vocab up the yin yang, or you just have a little bit of phrases that you know, I mean I think all of those things are important no matter what it is, no matter how vast it is or not. You know it really tells you who you are as a person. And sometimes it scares you because it's really honest you know, it's something that really keeps you honest, you have to be humble enough to know okay I'm here, but I want to know more. Or I'm here and I'm comfortable being here and that's it for me I'm cool with that.

MR: Okay. We talked a little about people that you might have on the bandstand that might do something to irk you and I'm wondering if on your way up playing lots of gigs if a leader ever said, "Christian don't do that"?

CS: Yeah. Always.

MR: What would you have done?

CS: Oh man. A number of things. You know whether it's I mean I've been playing since I was a kid so there's a lot of those moments where you are, you know, there's this respect

given to the band leader but you have to know about it, you have to learn about those things you know. So when you're a child, you like to just play all the time you know. It's like yeah, cool, and you do like eight choruses when you're really only supposed to do one. Sometimes that can happen. And someone's like, "No don't do that." Just do one chorus or two because then so-and-so can't get their choruses in. You know or we want that song to be short, okay, let's do a short tune. All right, cool. And you do a piano intro and the piano intro is like five minutes long. That's not cool either. So you know it teaches you how to be a musician you know, being in other people's bands really teaches you how to present the music you know. Like being in Christian McBride's band he really taught me his way of presenting music and what he wanted, and what he was expecting and what he liked to listen to you know and so when you're in tune with that you know you do things. And there was some times where I would play something and he'd be like [gestures] — you never know, but next tune, or do this — like say that, like we'll figure out how to implement that you know.

MR: Sometimes it's the hand motion or the look.

CS: Yeah. Sometimes it's the look, sometimes it's the word, sometimes it's hand motions you know. But you know it's never been physical.

MR: Good.

CS: It's always been fun. Everyone's band that I've been in has always been a learning experience and it's always been positive you know. Nothing crazy was ever really said like oh my God, don't do this, you know this whole thing. I've been lucky I think.

MR: Well you've got a concert to get ready — I think I have time for maybe one question from the audience. Anybody got one?

CS: Hope it's good.

MR: If so, speak up.

XX: Did you see Benny Green's Facebook essay on working with Freddie Hubbard? Freddie Hubbard telling him lay out. Did you see that?

CS: I did. I did. Well I've spoken to Benny about those times you know and well him and Christian McBride and Carl Allen and you know, just being in the band with Freddie Hubbard and what Freddie expected. And funny enough, a lot of what they do, some of that stems from being in Freddie's band. The way they present the music. The way they play the music. You know if you've ever noticed, they never — well I won't say never — but pretty much most of the time usually when they play a tune it's always like right on it. They never kind of like search into the tune. And Freddie didn't really do that either. So it's really interesting the way they all played. It's actually a stylistic thing you know, so it's really cool.

MR: Well it's been a pleasure talking to you.

CS: Thank you for having me.

MR: And we'll all look forward to your gig.